

# WHAT READING OUT LOUD DOES TO YOUR BRAIN

Memory • Comprehension • Discernment • Practice

**BIG IDEA** Your voice is a learning tool. Read important material aloud to make it stand out and stick; use silence when you need deeper, undivided thought.

## 1 WHY ALOUD HELPS MEMORY

### THE PRODUCTION EFFECT

Saying words aloud makes them more memorable than reading them silently.

Why? A spoken word becomes distinctive: you see it, say it, hear it, and your brain can tag it as something you produced.

**Key finding: contrast matters.**  
Reading selected parts aloud can help more than vocalizing everything.

## THE MEMORY STAIRCASE

|                     |     |
|---------------------|-----|
| Read aloud          | 77% |
| Hear your own voice | 74% |
| Hear someone else   | 69% |
| Read silently       | 65% |

Children in another study recognized 87% of aloud words vs. 70% of silent words.

## 2 MEMORY IS NOT THE SAME AS COMPREHENSION

Reading aloud reliably helps memory for details, but it does not reliably improve understanding of an argument. Difficult material may require quiet so the mind can stop, reread, and follow the thought.

## USE THE RIGHT MODE FOR THE RIGHT JOB

### READ ALOUD WHEN YOU NEED IT TO STICK

- Names, definitions & vocabulary
- Formulas or key facts
- A sentence that will not make sense
- Language-learning pronunciation
- Proofreading your own writing

### READ SILENTLY WHEN YOU NEED TO THINK

- Difficult or dense material
- Arguments you must follow closely
- Passages requiring rereading
- Situations needing undivided attention
- Careful comprehension

**TAKE-HOME:** Vocalize what you need to keep. Be silent when you need to think.